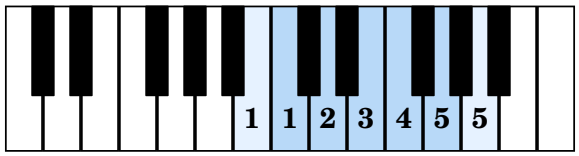
Unit 2

Stretching

New: Reaching one key beyond the position with the thumb or little finger

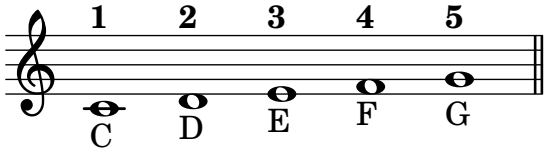
Sometimes a melody goes just one note beyond the hand position. Instead of moving the whole hand, stretch: the thumb slides one key below the position, or the little finger reaches one key above it, and then the hand settles back. The pale keys in the picture are the stretch notes.

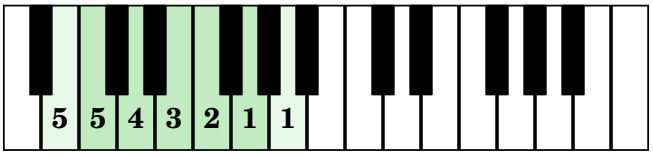


Middle C

Right hand C position: finger numbers on the keys (pale keys: stretches)

Your five notes

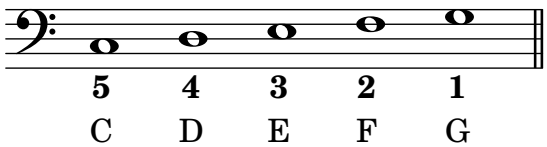




Middle C

Left hand C position: finger numbers on the keys (pale keys: stretches)

Your five notes



What is new

Stretch or shift?

A stretch is for a single note just outside the position, after which the hand comes back. A shift moves the whole hand to a new home.

Right-hand stretches

From C position the thumb slides down to B, and finger 5 reaches up to A.

Left-hand stretches

From C position finger 5 reaches down to B, and the thumb slides up to A.

Stay relaxed

Open the hand for the stretch, then let it close again. Don't hold it stretched.

Reading tips

1. In your 10-second scan, find the highest and lowest notes. If one is just outside the position, plan a stretch.

2. A stretch note is only ever one key outside the position, so it is always played by finger 1 or finger 5.

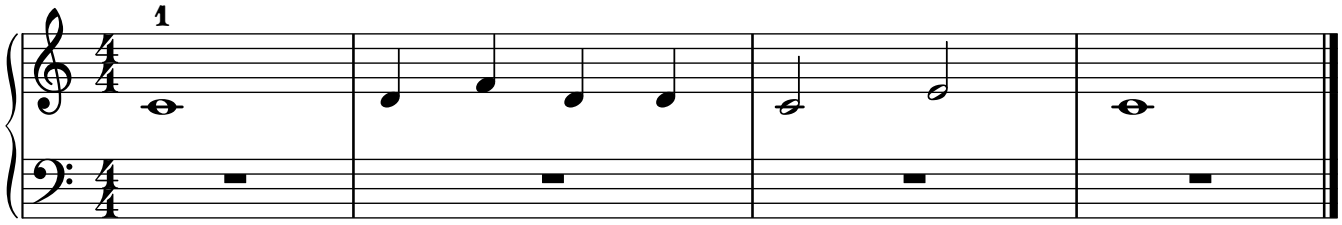
3. On the staff, a stretch note sits just beyond the notes under fingers 1 and 5.

4. Keep the beat steady; a stretch should not cost any time.

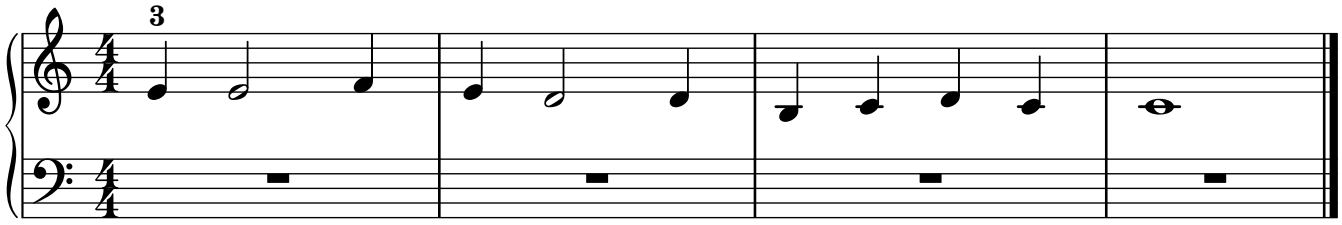
Part A: Right-hand stretches ♩ = 60

Right hand in C position, with stretches to B (thumb) and A (finger 5). Metronome 60.

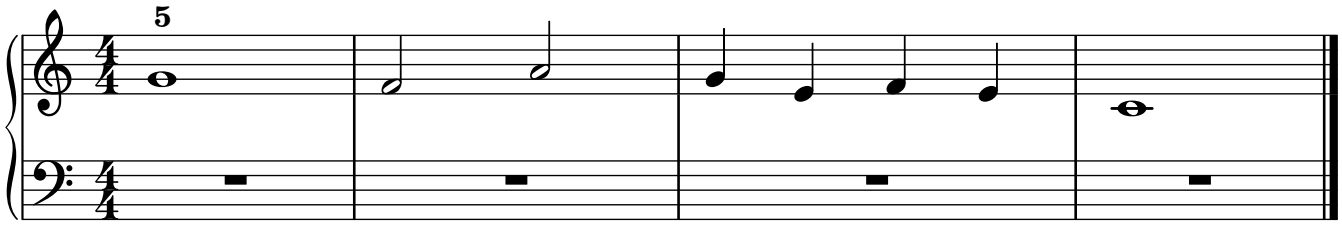
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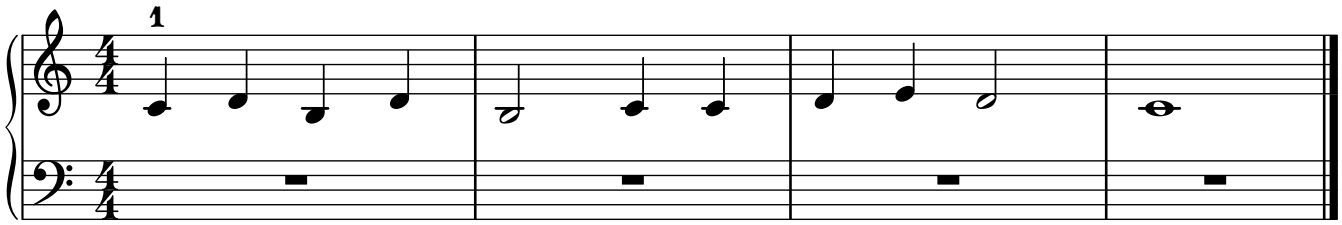
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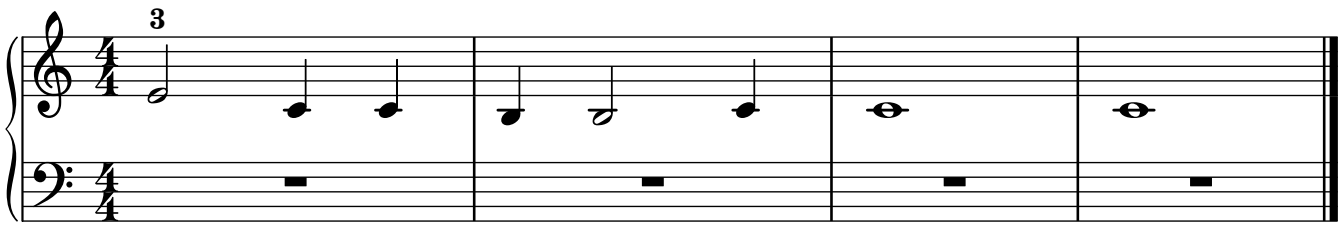
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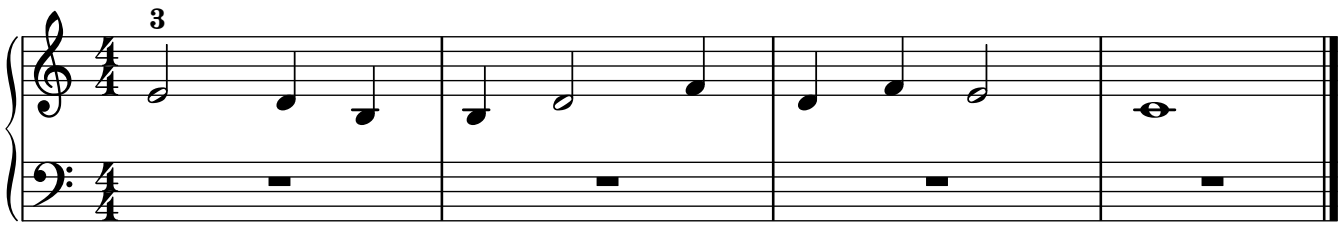
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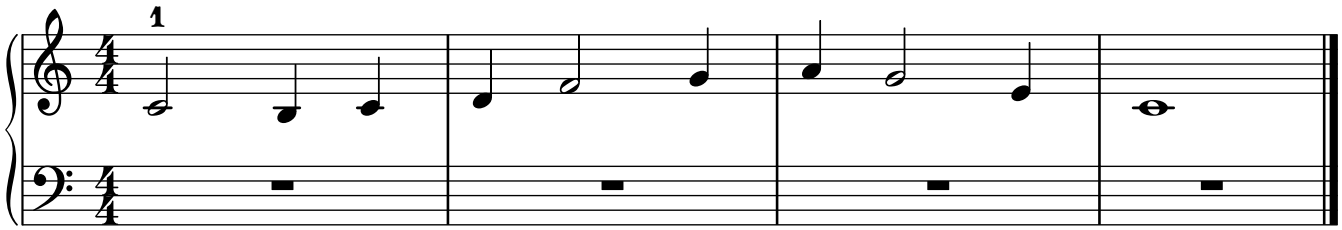
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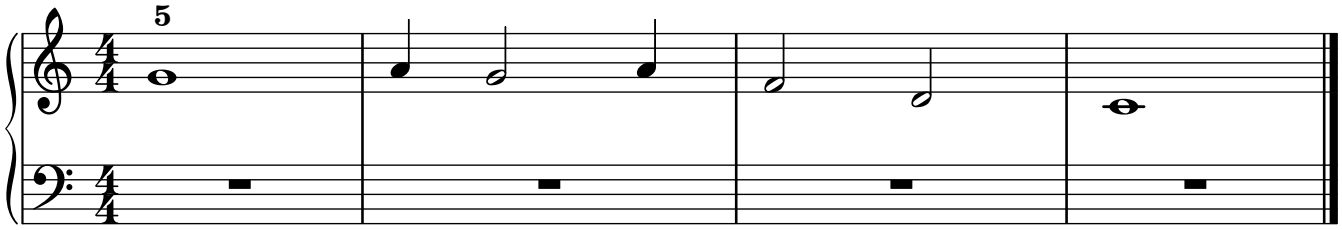


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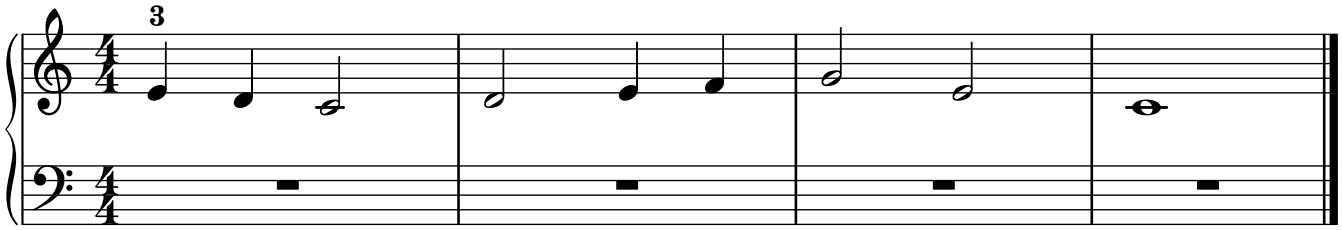
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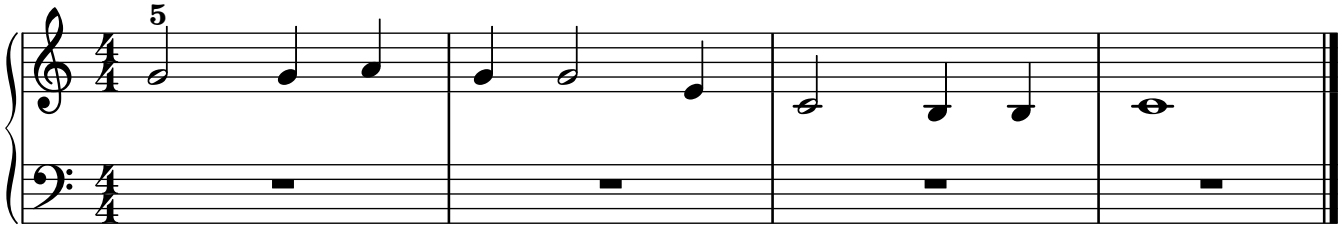
☐ **2.8**



☐ **2.9**



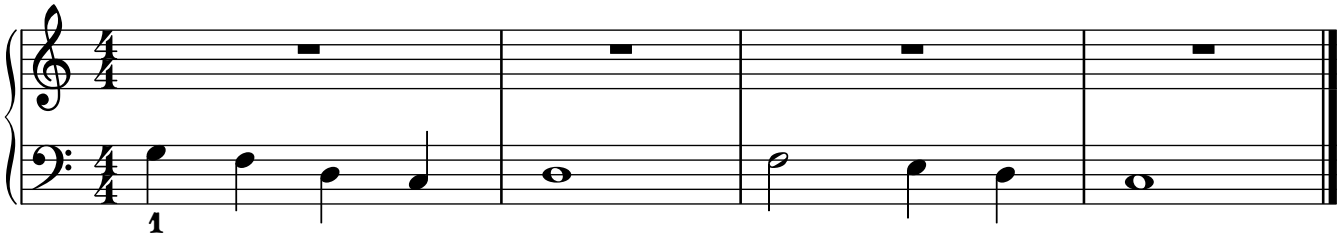
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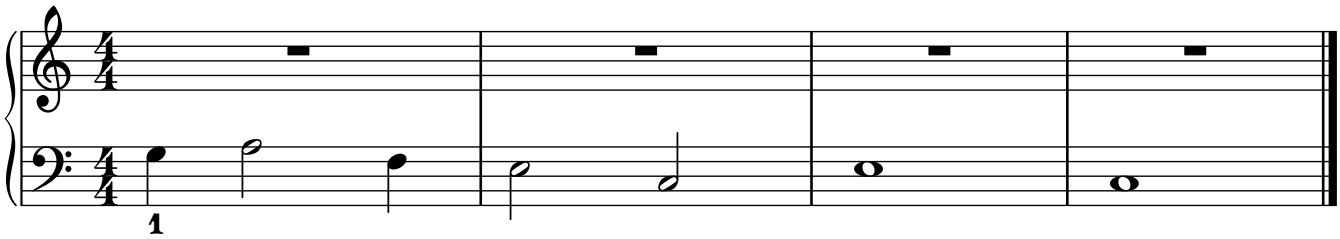
Part B: Left-hand stretches ♩ = 60

Left hand in C position, with stretches to B (finger 5) and A (thumb).

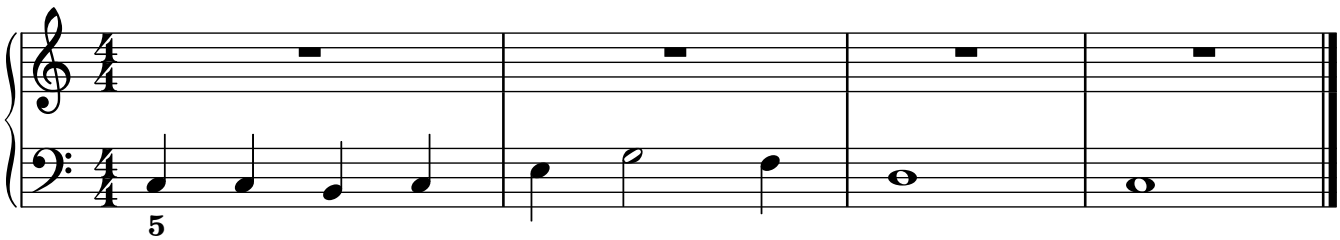
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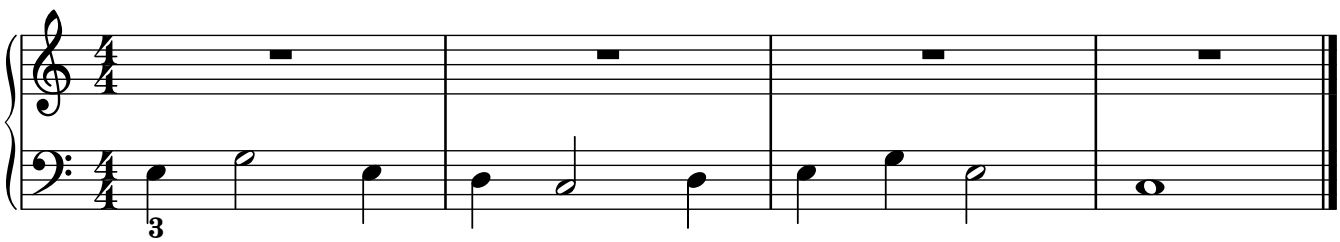
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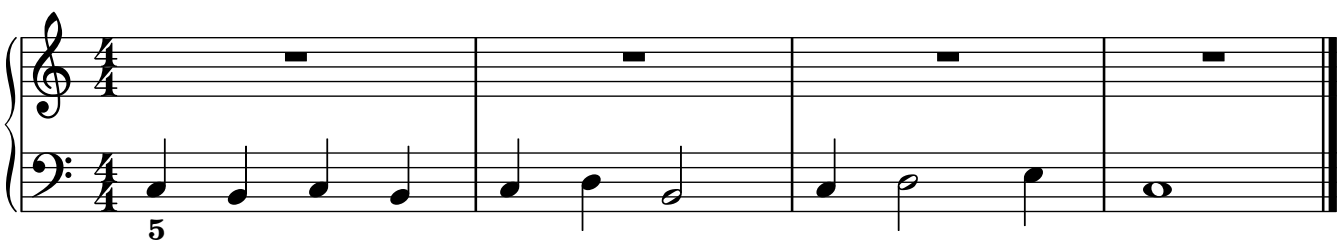
☐ **2.13**



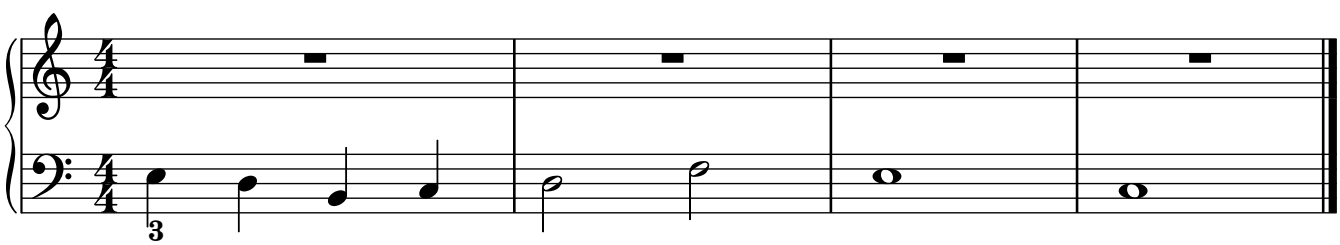
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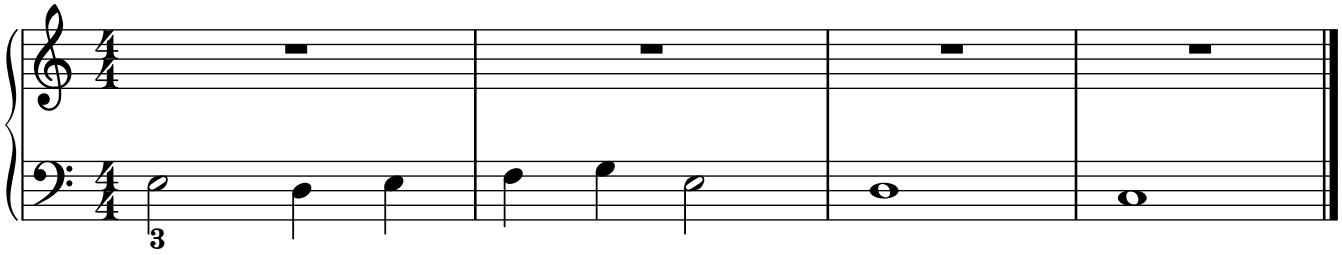
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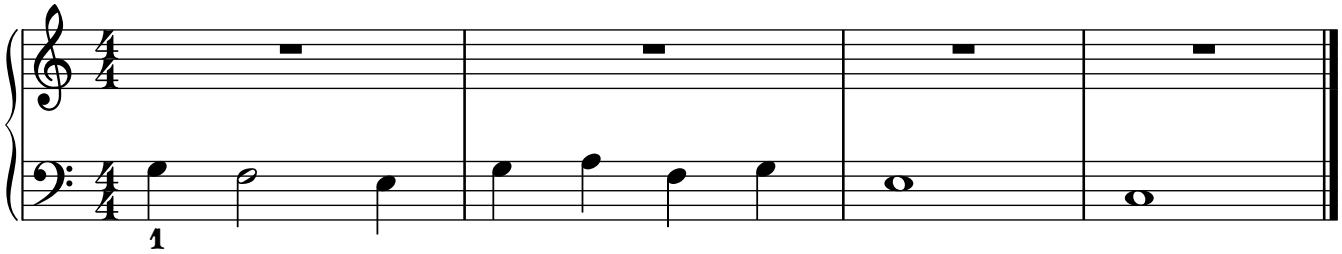
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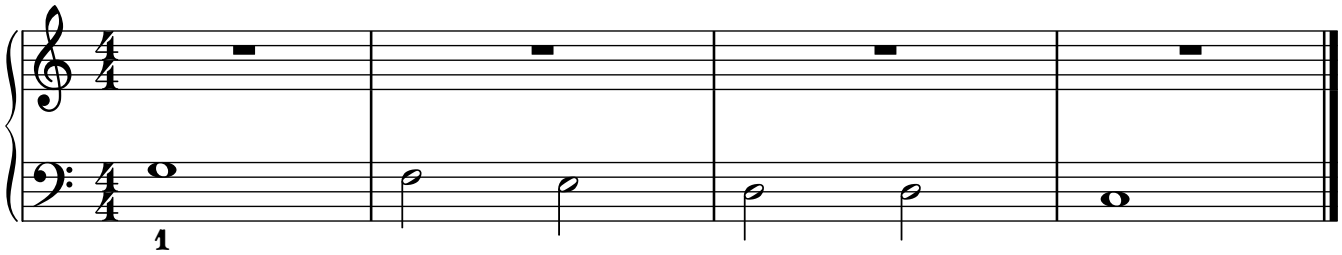
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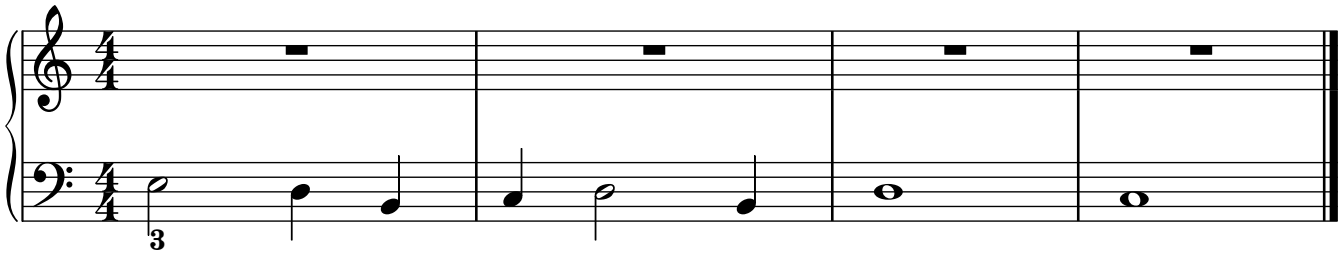
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☐ **2.19**
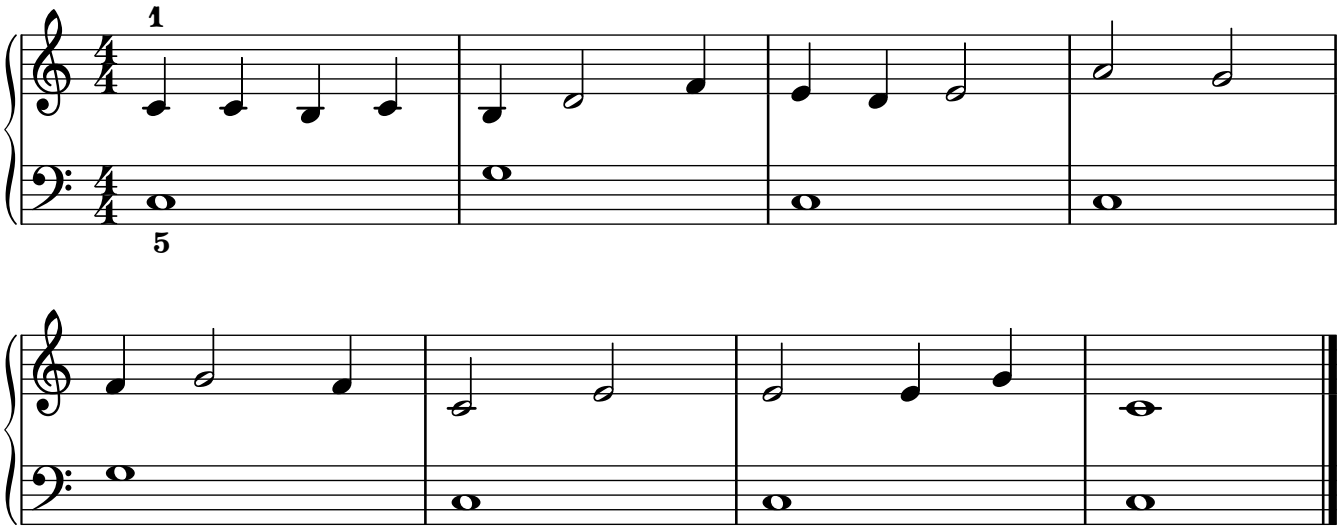


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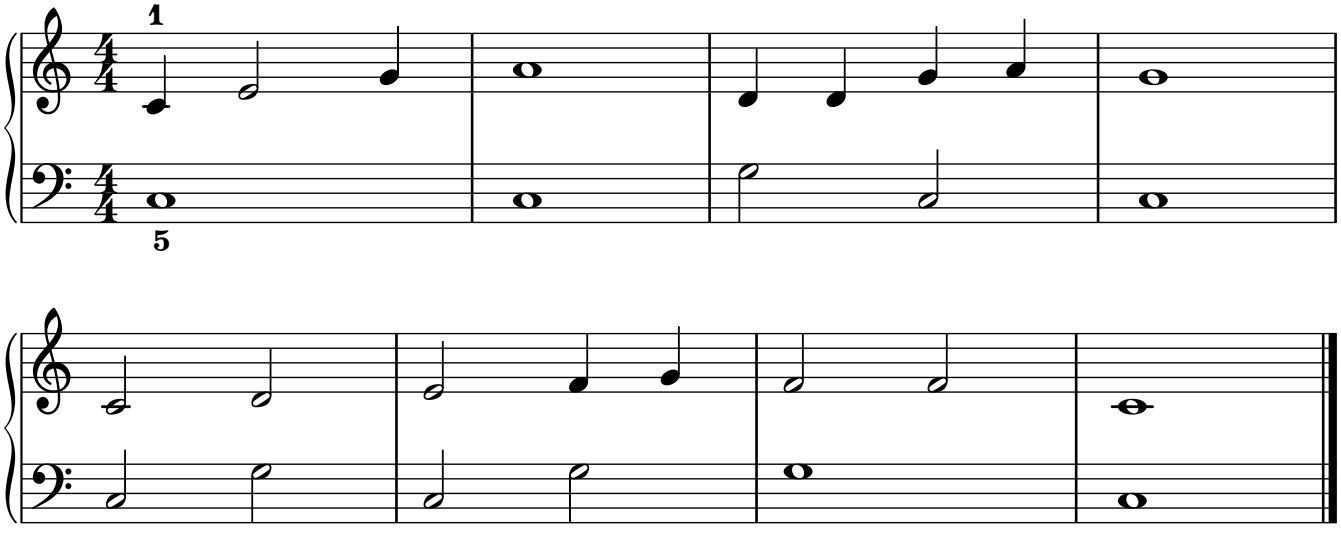


Part C: Stretches, hands together ♩ = 60

Hands together: stretches in the right hand, the bass on C or G.
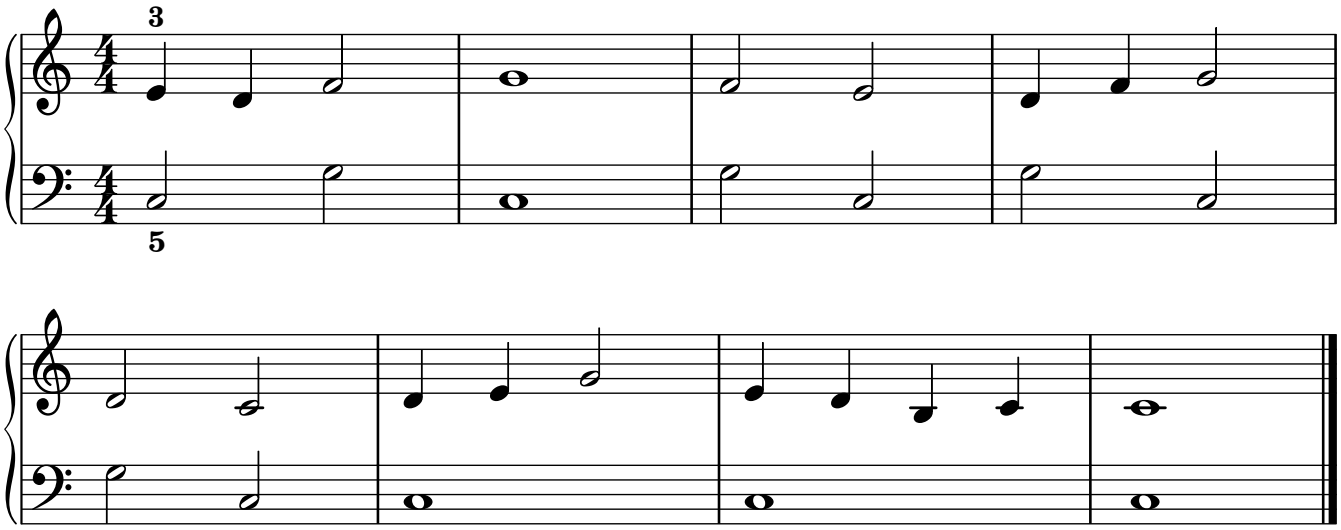
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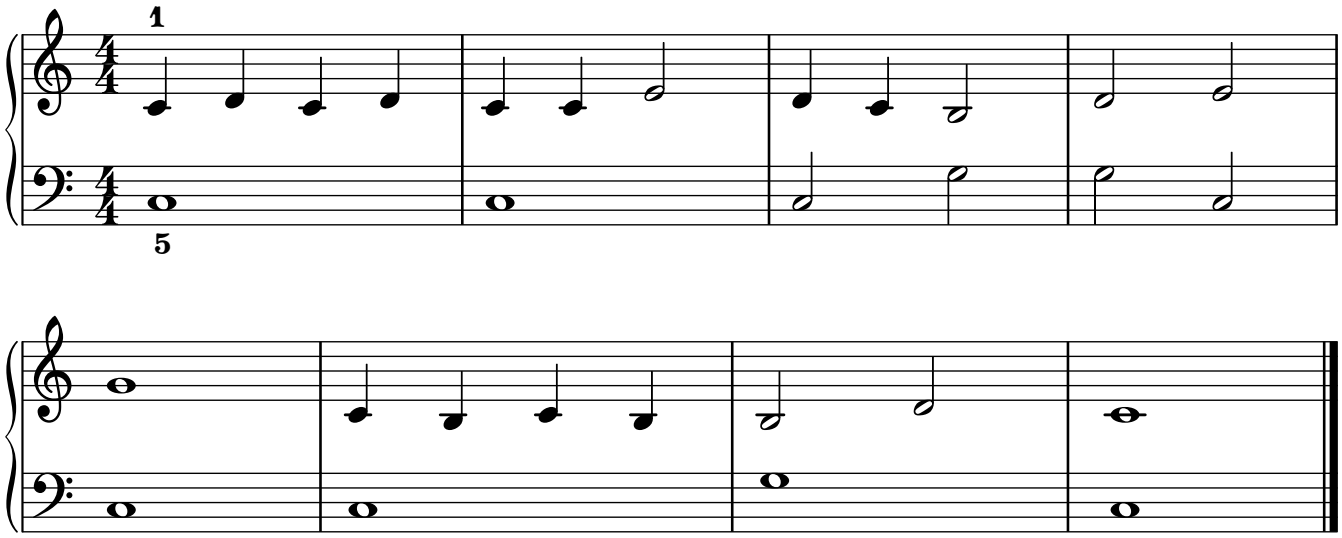


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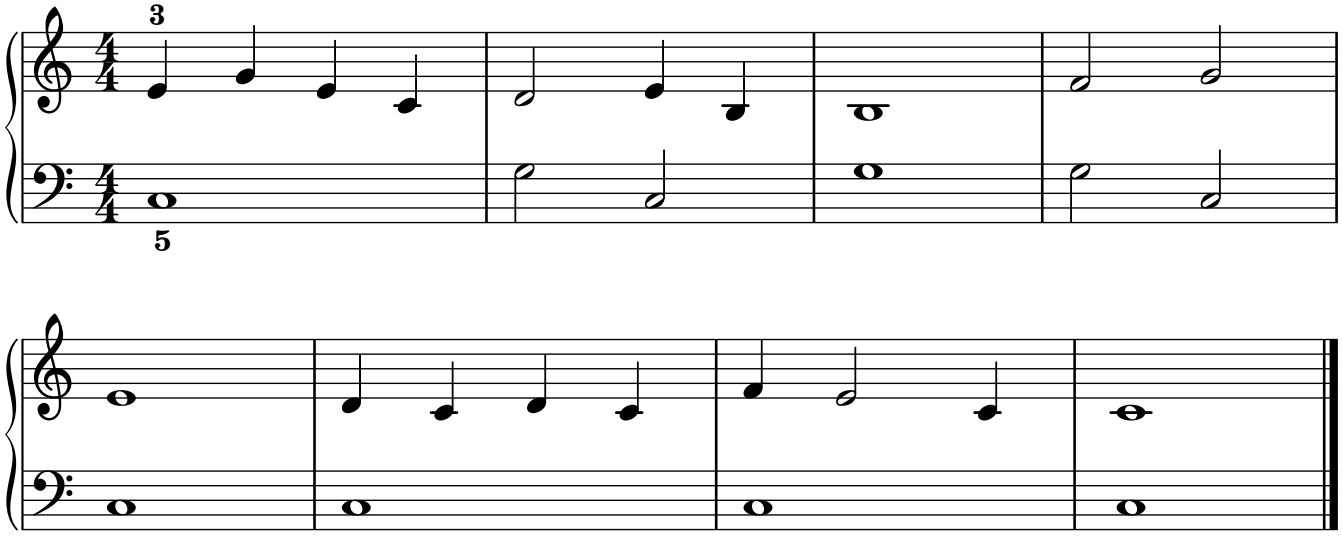
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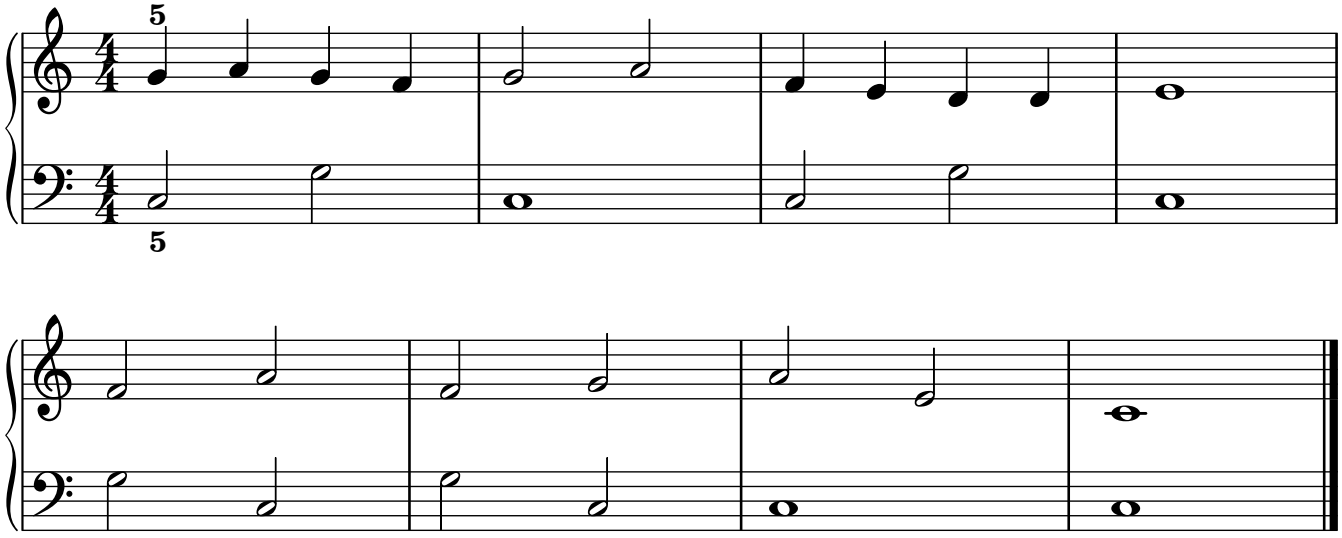


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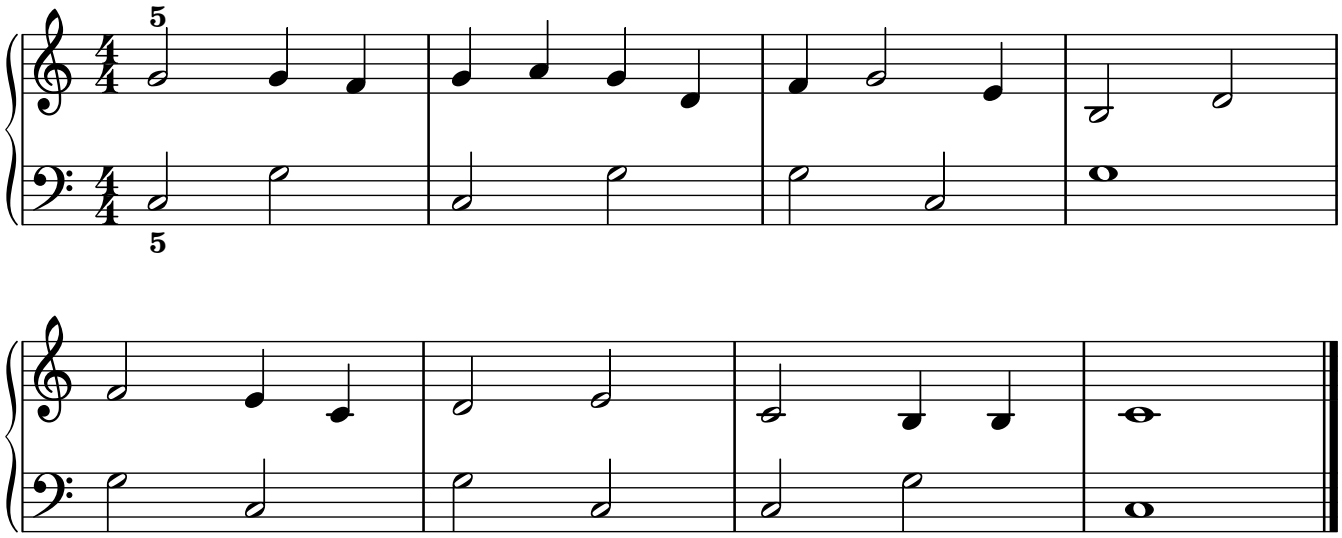


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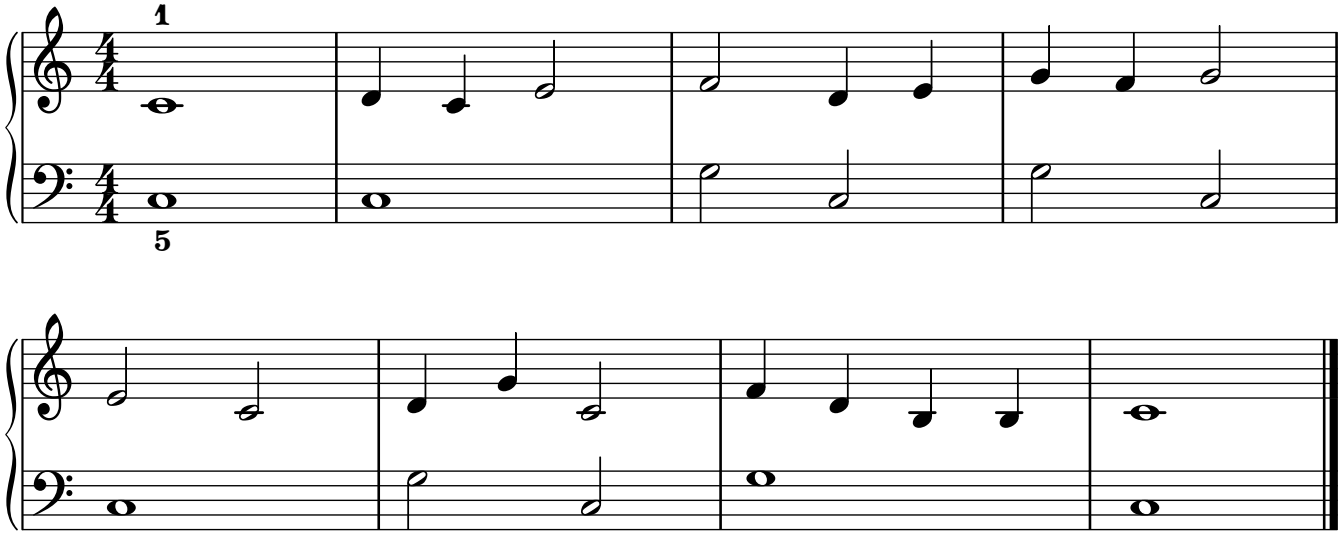


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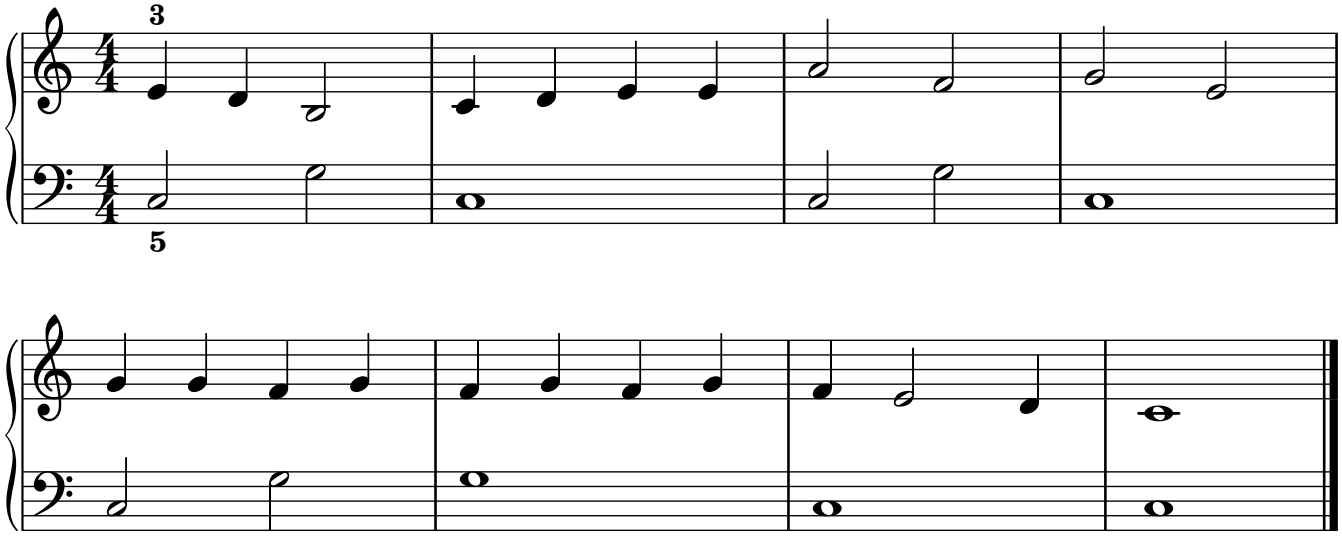


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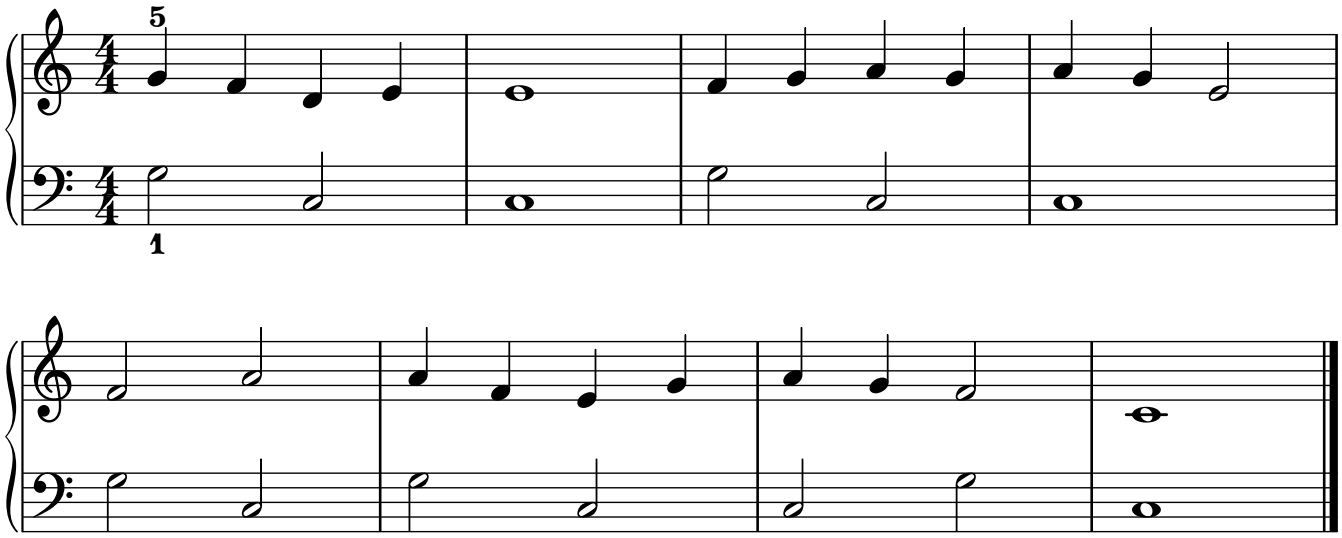


2.28



2.29



2.30
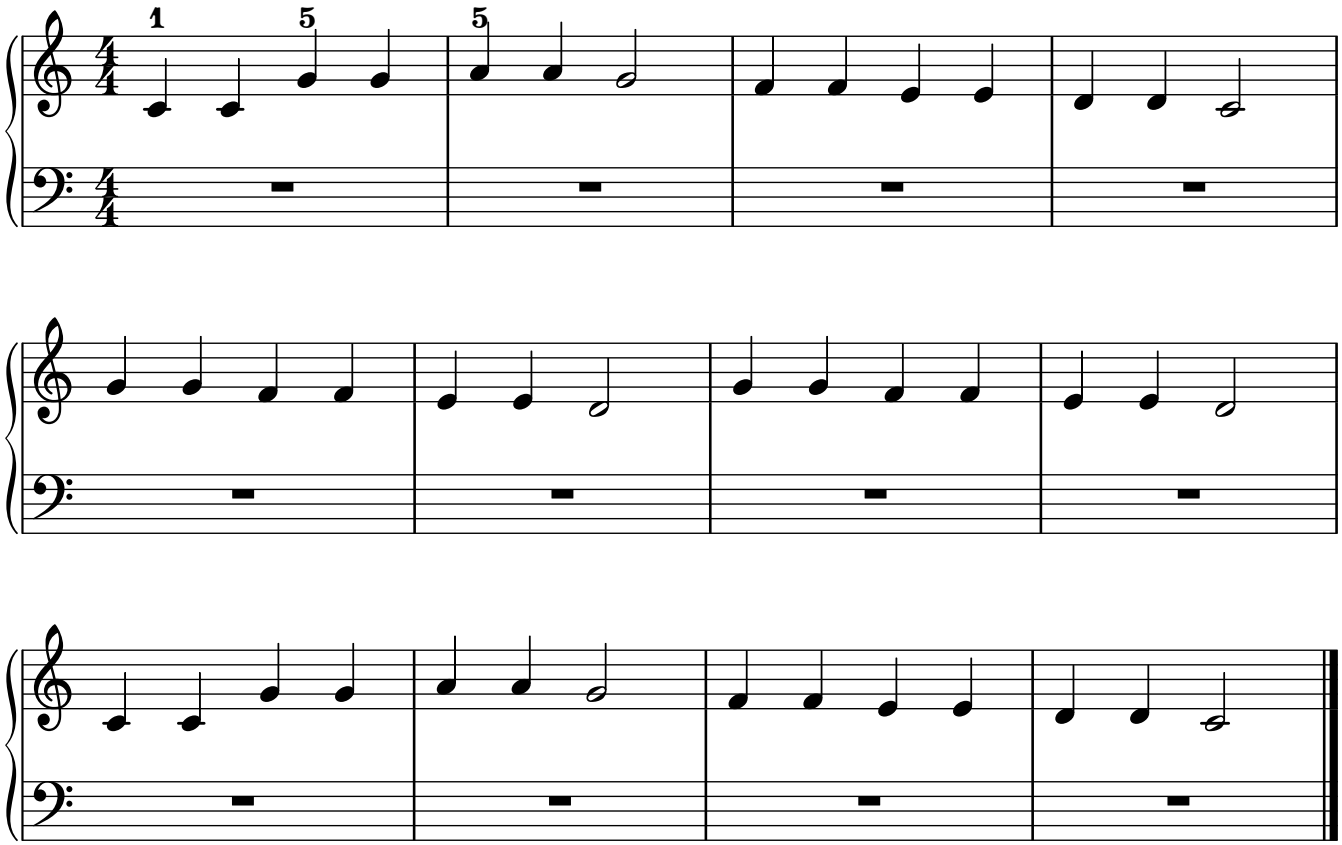


Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star ♩ = 80

Traditional (French melody 'Ah! vous dirai-je, maman')
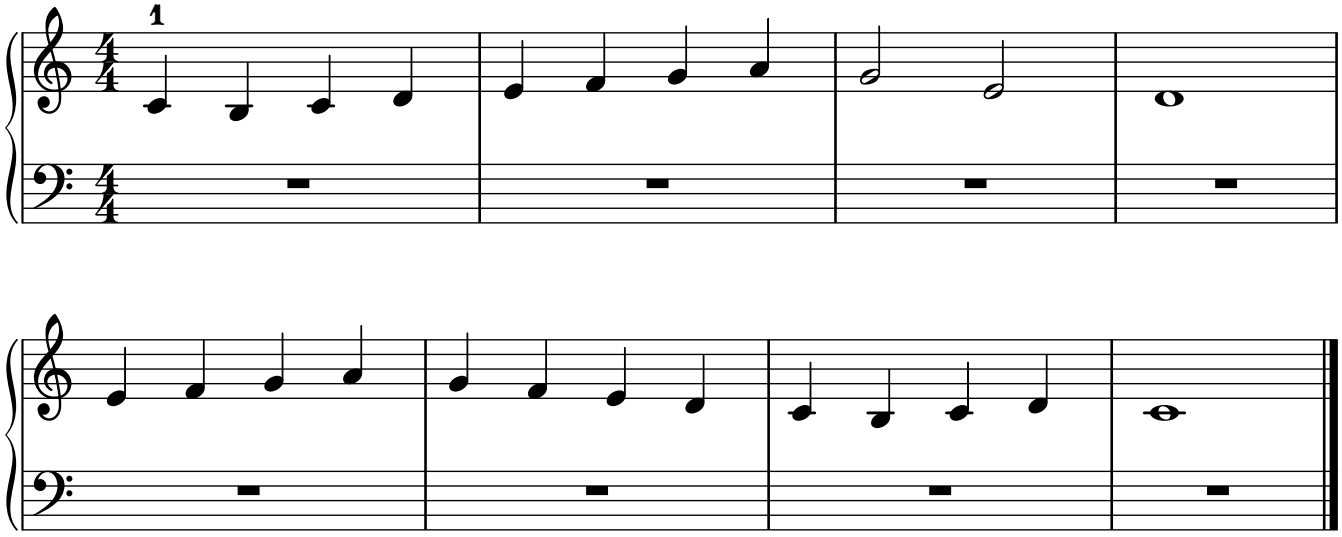
Finger 5 stretches up to A in bars 2 and 10, then comes straight back to G. Twelve bars on three lines.



Stretch and Return ♩ = 72

Original
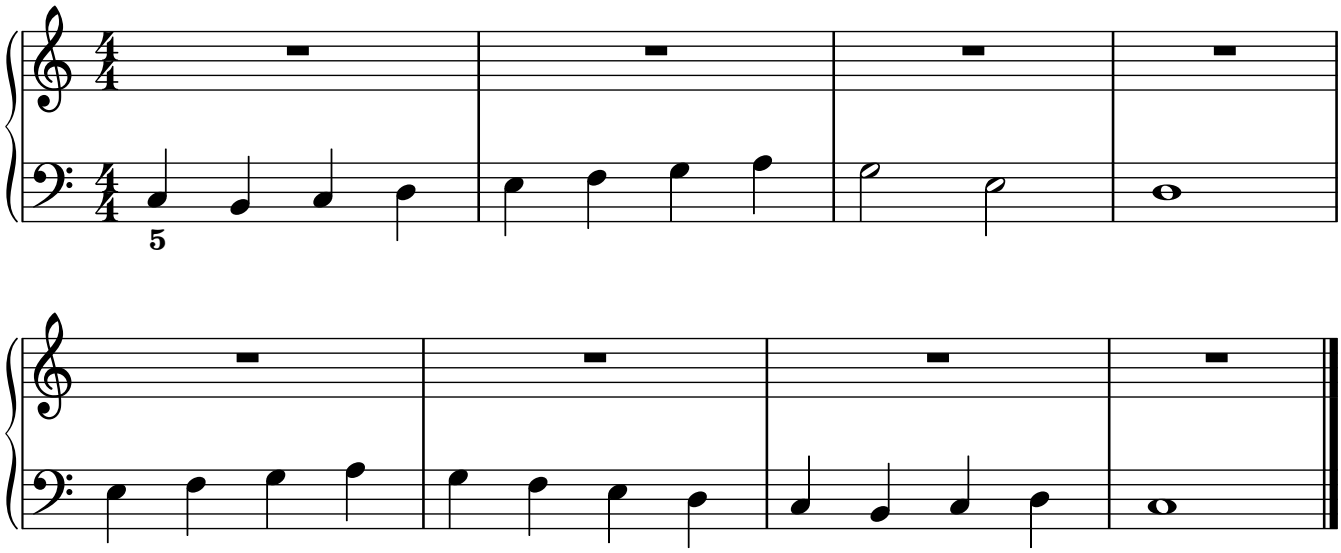
The thumb slides down to B in bars 1 and 7; finger 5 reaches up to A in bars 2 and 5.



Left-Hand Stretch ♩ = 72

Original
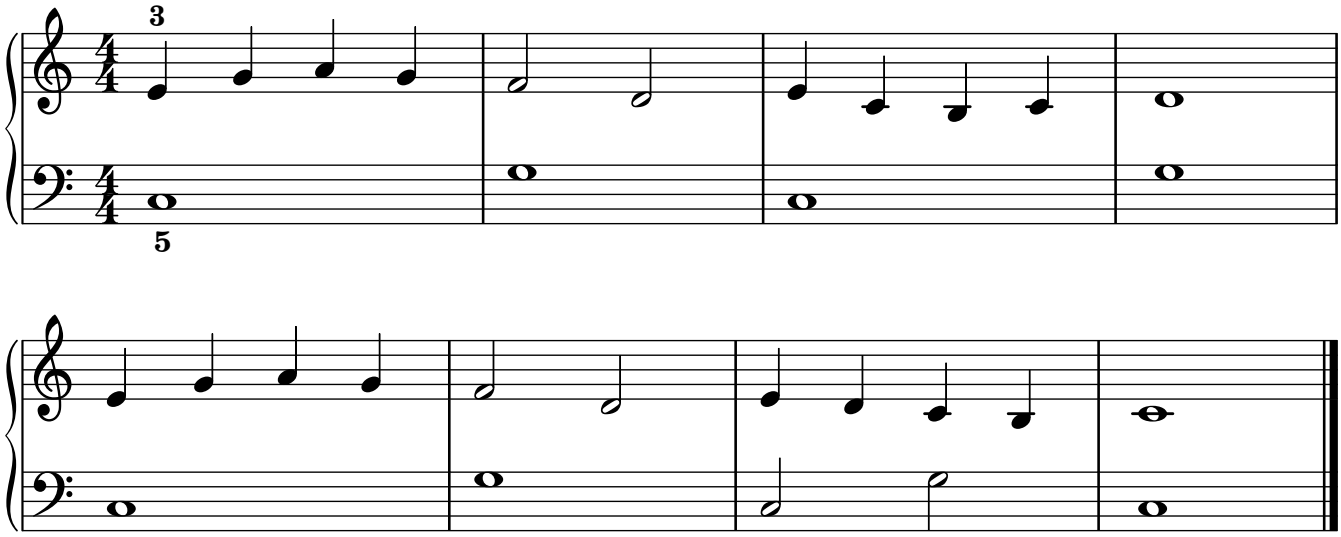
The same tune as 'Stretch and Return', one octave lower. Finger 5 reaches down to B; the thumb slides up to A.



Stretching Together ♩ = 72

Original

Hands together. The right hand stretches up to A in bars 1 and 5 and down to B in bars 3 and 7.



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 3?

- Play five Part C exercises you have not played before, at 60 beats per minute.
- Pass if the stretch notes come in time and the hand returns to its position afterwards.
- Pass if you play no more than one stop per exercise, and at least 9 notes out of 10 are right.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 3.